

PREMISE DELTA v0.2 • THE COMFORT BLANKET • 2026-09-07

Second delta against premise v8.1 and spine v1.4 with amendments v1.5 (the locker), v1.6 (the tin) and v1.7 (the same night). Delta v0.1 (the trust version) was attacked and rejected on 2026-09-07 (four-keys-premise-delta-trust-attack-chatgpt-2026-09-07.md): its key letter carried her trust and dated the locker letter, so the other three held her words against the forgery. Stephen then supplied a new engine for her silence, and this delta is built on it. Issues 1 to 5 below were walked one at a time with Stephen on 2026-09-07 and provisionally answered; nothing here is ruled. Premise v8.1 remains in force until the attack result exists and Stephen rules.

1. The device, before and after

Before (v8.1, ruled). A dead woman's accusation tears four friends apart. Her key letter: I think one of you is planning to kill me, I don't know which, I might be wrong, not the police and here is why, what I found is behind this door. The locker letter (Brad's forgery): I know. Chapter 7's turn: dead women don't get surer.

After (v0.2). A woman who thought she was losing her mind was right, and the one friend who knew it used her fear against the other three. Violet never accuses anyone. She fears her own judgement: two things have happened that she cannot explain and cannot prove, and the explanation she believes first is that she is going the way her mother went. She will not say so to the four people who love her. She writes it down, locks it in her locker with the thing she found, and gives the four keys that came in the padlock's packet to her four people, with a bare note: if I am dead, open this together. It is a comfort blanket she never expects to be needed. Brad, who has the key to her workshop and knows where her house spare lives, reads her true letter at dawn on the Monday and puts a different one in its place by afternoon: I know one of you did this, and here is why, and do not go to the police. The accusation, the certainty and the police ban are all his. The other three never read a word of hers about the tin, the panel or her mind. Her true letter is not burned. He keeps it, as he keeps the panel, and it is found in his room the day he is arrested. Ally reads it in the close.

Everything downstream of the forgery is unchanged: the room works his letter, it lands on Liam, Margo holds the money fact and her silence, Brad vanishes, Margo dies, the survivors accuse each other, the police look and find nothing, Ruby talks to the Gazette, Ally begins.

2. Violet, under this premise

She is forty-four and the best judge of a hand on the coast. Her mother went at about fifty: the forgetting, the seeing things, the shame of it; Violet cleared her mother's house the week she died and took the cash from it, which is already canon and is where Margo's confidence comes from. So when, in the same autumn, her hidden tobacco is spoiled and she cannot remember whether she left the lid loose, and a gilded panel in her own alphabet, better than she has ever done it, comes down out of her own roof with the ceiling board and she cannot remember making it, the reading she reaches for first is not "someone is doing this to me". It is "it has started". She never sees a doctor about it, because seeing a doctor makes it real and puts it on paper; so there is nothing on her record for Ruby to read on Day 2. She carries the panel round town asking whose hand it is,

half hoping somebody will say "yours, you idiot". She asks the café, the cinema, two other signwriters; she does not ask the four, and she does not ask Brad, because she will not let the people who love her watch her lose it. That is why Brad learns she is asking only on Day minus 40, from the café, exactly as the spine has it now.

She buys a new padlock for her locker at the slip sheds; it comes with four keys in the packet. She writes it all down, plainly, the way she does everything, and puts the letter behind the door with the panel. She writes four short notes, lodges them with her solicitor to be posted after her funeral, and makes a joke about her sister when he asks. Then she gets on, and is, for a few weeks, calmer, because it is written down somewhere and out of her head. She does not believe it will be needed.

3. The three letters, sketched (not prose; Fable writes prose, blind)

The key letter (genuine, four identical copies). If you've got this, I'm dead, and I'm sorry about the timing. Go to my locker at the boatsheds by the slip. The padlock's new; these four keys are the only ones. Go together, all four of you, and read what's there together. It's probably nothing. Violet. No accusation, no fear stated, no police instruction, and nothing that says a letter is already written (the standing check from v0.1's failure: nothing in the key letter may date the locker letter).

The locker letter (genuine; Brad reads it on the Monday at dawn; kept, not burned). Her mother, in one line, and what she is afraid is happening to her. The tin: the two a day she lies about, the tin under the stairs among the paints and the garden concentrates, the stain through the paper, not lit, the loose lid, the capped bottle on the shelf above, and the sentence that is the premise: I don't know whether I did that. The panel: the leak, the ceiling board, a panel in the roof above her racks, her own alphabet done better than she has ever done it, signed with a mark that is not a name, and the second sentence that is the premise: I don't know whether I made it. She asked round town; nobody knew the hand; she did not ask the four, and says why. Then: if I'm dead and it wasn't my stairs or my heart, then I wasn't imagining it, and someone with my spare key has been in my house; you four know where the spare lives, which is why it's you reading this, and why I couldn't say it to your faces. Each of you write down everything odd you know about the other three from this year, however small, and read the four lists at one table. Then the police, with something in your hands. Be careful. Write legibly.

The locker letter (forged; what the four read on the Monday night). Her shape, her paper, her pen, her hand, one long day at her bench with the debt book beside him. Opens on certainty: I know now. The claims, none naming a person, every one leaning the same way: a third of the boatyard kept quiet; how it was paid for, told to her the day the papers were signed; the board in her hall, given that day; the money in her tin, every quarter since, for saying nothing; a third claim to be set with the forgery rebuild. The instruction he needs: don't go to the police; I can prove nothing, they'd find nothing, and he would know you had been. One kind line about the youngest, in passing. Read this together, and be careful. Violet. The forgery carries no physical threat at all, because nothing in her real letter's threat paragraph could be turned toward Liam; he cut it whole. That absence is one of chapter 7's tells.

4. The five issues, as walked with Stephen on 2026-09-07

#	Issue	Answer (provisional)
1	Without fear of the four, nothing drives a padlock, four keys, lodged letters and silence	Shame about her own mind. The tin's loose lid and the panel in her own alphabet both read first as "it has started". She will not let the four watch her lose it, so she writes it down for after. The keys came in the packet.
2	Her interior lives only in the letter Brad destroys	Two routes. Texture: the café owner remembers she asked whether the panel could be hers; Ruby remembers Violet once asking in the car what early dementia looked like, and changing the subject. And the letter survives: Brad keeps it, hidden in his room, found on arrest day, read by Ally in the close.
3	Chapter 7 loses the certainty gap	The turn is rebuilt from what remains: the letter kind to exactly one man; four townspeople saw her carry a gilded panel and the locker held a boat's name board; nobody alive ever saw Brad write; Margo's money, which the letter gets wrong; and the padlock's four keys from the packet, which turns "she chose us four" into "she bought a padlock". Chapter 7 still lands "the second letter is probably not hers".
4	The first-minute hook came from her letter and now comes from the forged one	Provisional: "happy to see how that works". The open's middle is redrafted so the danger is named inside the first minute from behind the door; the changed sentences go to the three readers before ruling.
5	Five new facts need the sweep	Admitted for attack: Brad keeps the genuine letter (hidden where the landlady does not dust; found only on Day 333); the mother's early dementia (one line in the five, Stephen's document); nothing on Violet's medical record; a padlock sold with four keys (ledger row 15 changes; no locksmith); the way she asked round town (hoping the hand was hers).

5. What changes, what does not

Changes. Premise device (section 1). Cold open middle and the accusation's source. Chapter 1 packages 4 to 6 (her letter is bare; the accusation lands at the second letter). Chapter 2 packages 2 and 3 (the key letter as object; the room). Chapter 7's turn (rebuilt). Spine: C1 (Violet's routes: all closed by shame), A1 minus 20 (the padlock and packet), B1 row 15, B3 rows 25 and 28, D3, C2 (the kept letter), the close (the letter read). The five: one line on the mother. The key letter ruled 2026-09-05 is void under this premise.

Does not change. The motive (the money). The panel (her alphabet, his mark) and the tin. Margo's six-week silence, the load-bearing lock. Brad's dawn visit and same-night swap (v1.7), his vanish, the second death, the survivors' fear, the police look, the Gazette, Ally's ten weeks. All four decisions. The arrest under the deckhand's name. The season notch: the deckhand's photographs and Gerald's ask sit beside the read letter in the close and do not touch it.

6. The recut open, middle only (sketch; the three readers judge the words)

...But two weeks later, four people received something in the post. Each of them got a key, and a note in Violet's handwriting. The note didn't say why. It told them to open a locker at the boatsheds, together, all four of them. Their names were Liam Bryce, Ruby Walker, Margo Rivera and Brad Collins. They were Violet's closest friends. They went that night, all four of them. And behind the door they found another letter. This one said she knew. It said one of the four of them had killed her, and she knew which. There was an object beside it. Something that had belonged to Violet. Only two of the friends are still alive, and neither one will say what that object was...

The rest of vo.4 stands as ruled.

PROMPT FOR CHATGPT (paste everything below this line)

You are the adversarial reviewer for a true-crime mystery in production. A second premise change has been proposed after the first was rejected. Your job is to break it, not to improve it. Read the delta above in full, then attack on six fronts. For each front, find the strongest objection you can, state it plainly, say whether it is fatal, serious or cosmetic, and say what would have to be true for it to be answered. Do not soften. Do not propose alternative stories. No scores, no percentages. No em dashes.

The fronts:

1. **Violet's engine.** Does fear of her own mind carry a padlock, four keys, lodged letters and total silence toward four people she loves, for a fit forty-four-year-old whose mother went the same way? Attack the shame. Attack "she never saw a doctor". Attack "she asked the café but not Brad".
2. **The kept letter.** Brad keeps the one document that proves the forgery, for nine months, in a lodger's room four hundred miles away. Is that coherent with a man whose whole exit is built on documents never carrying his face? Find the day before the arrest on which it could be found, and by whom.
3. **The room on the Monday night.** The three hold a bare note (go to the locker together) and then read a letter that says she knew which of them would kill her. Does the bare note make the second letter more believable or less? Find the question one of them asks that the delta has not answered.
4. **The first minute.** The accusation now arrives from behind the door, not from her own letter. Does a listener stay through keys and a locked door to reach it? Is "the note didn't say why" a hook or a delay?
5. **Chapter 7.** With no "I think" in her letter, the turn rests on the kind line, the panel against the name board, nobody having seen Brad write, Margo's money and a padlock that came with four keys. Is that enough for a turn, or is it a list?
6. **The five new facts.** Take each in turn (the kept letter, the mother, nothing on her record, the packet of keys, the way she asked round town) and find the earliest competent action any person in the story could take on it that ends the episode before its time.

End with one paragraph: PROCEED, PROCEED WITH CHANGES, TEST BEFORE COMMITTING, REWORK or REJECT, with your confidence and the single finding that most drives the verdict.